17. July 1422

May the lord show me mercy and guidance, as I lied to the Marschall. I had good reason for my sin. I am restless, going mad even, in need of a change of scenery from the same stone bricks that have held me caved. The opportunity came to me to my defense, George told me he needed someone to investigate the surrounding lay. Whispers of a spy or a man, some saying its a Beggar, seen in the Mud Pits of the cross road. Though this may only take a second, that is a second I can call freedom of the eyes that watch me here. So I told him to consider it done.

"I was hoping you would say that, be back by dusk."

The sin, lied with my reply, "I will." I said to the man who could have me hung for such a small betrayal.

I will bring my fabrics, I will take my quails, my dignity. I will be back eventually, I plan to lie and tell them that I found troubles. If they believe me is up to the heavens to string me as they will. Hopefully, the heavens get to me before a Lord finds me a sinner.

I hope this entry is not my fate sealed with wax.

17. July 1422

My dearest Elara,

The mountainside is beautiful, though it feels cruel jest in my final hours. The sun teases me through the pines, and for a moment, the silence of the woods is so profound it feels as though I am already beyond the veil. I write this with a trembling hand, praying the man I pay to carry it has a swifter horse than he has wits and that he evades the bandits that haunt these passes.

I am writing because I have failed, and the shame of it is a blade in my gut.

As I crested the ridge between the fortress and Rötteln, the fatigue took me. I stopped to rest, and in my exhaustion, I played the dotard. I did not strike a fire nor, bare me a shelter; I collapsed upon the cold, hard earth. When I woke, my pack was gutted. The letter, the one Lord Burkhard zu Rhein entrusted to my life! Gone, but gone where is the ghost that haunts me now. I know the contents of that letter by heart, Elara. I know the gravity of the secrets I have let slip into the mud.

I cursed the god, maybe that is why I lay here now with my bag empty. I feel just as gutted as I sit here on the grass, paralyzed by the thought of returning. What would I tell the men in the village? A messenger who stops is a ghost of a man; we are meant to be tireless, to be the wind that carries a Lords's will. I am coin-less, and I will not return as a beggar!

I cannot look at you with the face of a man who has lost his purpose.

Do I crawl to Margrave Rudolf III of Hachberg-Sausenberg and beg for mercy?

I think not!

He would sooner have me hung by the string of the Nile, a declaration of fail up on his ramparts than offer pity for my incompetence. I have no coin to buy my way back to your side, and my feet are too bloodied to carry me home. I am a man stripped of his skin, Elara.

My duty is my life, and that life is now forfeit.

Do not weep for me, and do not blame yourself. Remember me only as I was before the road took my honor.

Please tell our dearest Lilly- [the paper is torn and illegible here]

18. July 1422

If this parchment has reached your hands. I have succeeded, you are his Elara.

If so, there are things you shall know. I was watching from the tree line, I will have stepped away by now so you can find his folded vellum in solitude. You must know that it was pulled from a dying man's chest just outside the pines of Rötteln. You should know that he looked healthy as a man who refused help could look. I know that his parchment is no replacement for a Husband, but I am sure the value is in the closure they bring. He looked like a good man who fell into the hands of the havens.

I hope you forgive me for my secrecy. A man carrying such a weight does not inductance himself to widows. I will slip his dispatch under your door, in the side pocket you will find his signet ring. For that he found his strength. If it comforts you to know, he had the health to ask for help, to beg for forgiveness. That is stronger then some knights I have bought beside.

The garrison called him a beggar.

He was no beggar.

He was a man dying of broken pride, terrified of nothing more then you believing that he would abandon you. His hands were too cold to hold the quill, but his last breath asked for your peace. He whispered into my shoulder, his body growing ever more heavy, until he froze through.

As for his body, I have laid him beneath the mountain earth with river stones over his chest. I leave this at your doorstep, not to inflate my own ego. But because I owed a dying messenger his final run. Do not seek me, I am simply the man who brought it; I am sure the Marchall's hounds are already behind me. Pray for your husbands soul, and if you have to spare, for the soul of me, the runner who carried his peace. I will leave our final messages with you.

The final whispers if you care to know: "Tell my Elara... Tell my Lilly what

kind of man I was. Don't let her father die a coward in the stories that she tells."